

The Empty Life

Daev awoke to the melodic songs of birds drifting through his window. In the distance, their faint chirping sounded almost festive, as though they were celebrating a holiday of their own.

Without giving it much thought, he lazily opened his eyes. "Oh my gosh, what time is it?"

He kicked off the blanket and rushed towards his reading table, where his alarm clock lay beside a pile of scattered books. After a quick glance at the time, he let out a quiet breath of relief. He was still on time. He had simply panicked.

For a moment, he stood silently in the cold room. More than anything, Daev wanted to move out and start his own life, a life without strict rules, one he could finally do whatever he wanted.

He looked back at his bed. For more than ten years, he had slept on it through cold nights, stressful school mornings, and restless evenings. Today was the day he would finally leave it behind.

"If I leave this place, I will never come back again," Daev whispered to himself reassuringly, "I am tired of living here broke. I want to make my own money."

Recently, he had finished his KCSE examinations. After four years of exhausting studies, he was finally free.

Without wasting another moment, Daev quickly got dressed, gathered his belongings, and left.

Outside his entire family waited for him. One by one they waved goodbye as he begun his journey to Necta. The morning was cold, but his heart burned with excitement and ambition.

His hope for success were too high.

"Faster man... ingia pale. Yes hapo!" The conductor shouted before turning to Daev. "Unaenda wapi mkuu?"

"Naenda Necta." Daev replied with a smile on his face.

He still could not believe he was finally leaving. Reaching into his pocket, he pulled out two hundred shillings and handed the money to the conductor.

Without hesitation, he stepped inside the infamous *matatu* and took his seat.

Beside him sat his highschool girlfriend. When she saw him, her eyes grew emotional. He was leaving and she could not hide how much it affected her.

She might have wanted them to stay together a little longer, but Daev had already made his decisions.

That day, she had come to say goodbye and accompany him for the last time until they reached Necta. After that, she would return home alone.

"Promise me you will always think about me," she asked softly.

"I promise... I will always love you. No one else will take your place," Daev replied.

But even as he said it, something inside her remained unsettled. She could not fully trust the future. No matter what Daev said, a quiet fear lingered her heart: that one day he might find another girl better than her.

Still, she held on to him. Believing she was lucky to be dating the smartest boy in their class.

"Babe... can I come and live with you there?" She asked.

Daev hesitated. "Not right now. I am just starting my life. Once I am settled and I have built something, I will send you fare. Then you can come and we can live together."

"Babe I love you..." She finally said, resting against his chest.

Daev did not respond immediately. He simply held her there, as if trying to freeze the moment in time.

Soon they arrived in Necta.